

who became a father figure to Shane and me—something my own father couldn't be because of his addictions. After the wedding, we all moved to Illinois so that my new stepfather could pursue a Ph.D. in business. One day, fed up with the custody arrangement, my birth father threatened to come to Champaign-Urbana and bring Shane and me back with him. My mother had heard he'd fallen in with a rough crowd, so she didn't want us going there. The plan was for my mom and both of us kids to fly to Europe for as long as it took George to reason with my dad in Illinois. But the trip required cashing in a big part of George and my mother's emergency savings, which weren't significant to begin with. When my mother married George, he was a student with \$36 to his name.

Where there's a will, there's a way—and I have never met a woman with more will than my mother. The three of us flew to Lausanne, Switzerland, where my brother and I would be safe. After waiting it out for weeks in a foreign hotel room with two little children, and despite her determination and cool resolve, my mother finally burst into tears. She was at the end of her rope, in terms of both stress and finances. The money that was keeping her children safe from a man she didn't trust to take care of them was running out. And both George and my mother had used up almost all of their resources. There was nowhere else to turn. Kids pick up every nuance of parental strife and store it in a place so deep in their subconscious that it affects them for the rest of their lives. I knew George and my mother didn't have the money to hire expensive lawyers to fight this in court, and they certainly couldn't afford to keep us hidden in Europe forever. I will never forget my mother's fear, the look on her face when she realized that eventually the money would run out and she might lose her children.

Less than eight weeks into our exile, sadly, tragically, my father died of a heart attack at the age of thirty-seven. The custody struggle was over. Still, our precarious financial situation, and my mother's panic about it, moved through my bloodstream in that one moment, and I think it changed my very DNA. I remember thinking, *I never want to feel this frightened and powerless again. I never want my own children to experience economic terror.* Early-childhood trauma is an awful